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From HR automation to agentic workforce experience

A point of view on the next era of intelligent workforce technology

Siddhartha Dhamankar

Global HR IT Innovation Lead
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1. The journey in brief

For over a decade, the challenge has been the same: how to make HR accessible, simple, and scalable for a workforce of hundreds of thousands. Each era of technology moved us closer, but each also inherited the limits of its own paradigm.

We are now at an inflection point. The shift is not from one tool to a better tool. It is from *automating HR work* to *delivering an agentic workforce experience*, where intelligent agents carry context, offer guidance, take action, and orchestrate outcomes on behalf of every workforce persona.

The thesis. HR technology has stopped being about digitising and automating transactions. It is becoming a single, intelligent front door through which the workforce gets work done.

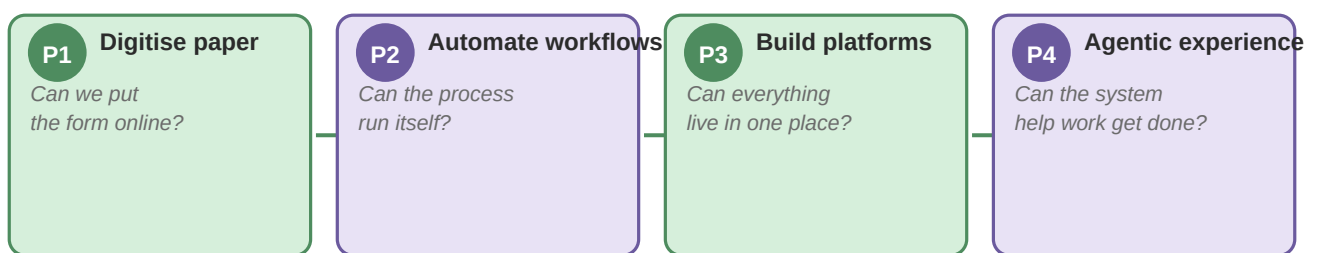


Figure 1. The four phases of HR technology evolution

Each phase solved the previous phase's constraint, then hit a new ceiling. The move to Phase 4 is the largest of them all. It changes the fundamental unit of value from a *transaction processed* to an *outcome achieved*.

2. Phase 1. Digitise paper

The paradigm. Take what used to be paper forms, manuals, and in-person interactions and move them onto screens. Employees searched intranet pages, navigated portals, and contacted HR for even simple questions. Knowledge lived in documents and FAQs. Access meant finding the right page or the right person.

What it unlocked

- HR information became available on-demand rather than only through a person.
- Records, policies, and forms moved from filing cabinets to searchable systems.

The ceiling it hit

- Digitised did not mean *simple*. Employees still had to know where to look and how to interpret what they found.
- The employee did the work of navigating. The system was passive.

The digitisation era put information on screens. It did not put understanding in the hands of the employee.

3. Phase 2. Automate workflows

The paradigm. Wire the digitised steps together so a process could execute end-to-end: routing, approvals, notifications, and case handling without manual hand-offs. This is where much of enterprise HR still operates. Ticketing, case management, and rules-based routing define this era.

Foundational capabilities in this phase included GenAI knowledge services that let HR professionals resolve employee cases faster by querying curated knowledge bases rather than searching manually across sites and offline material.

What it unlocked

- Faster turnaround, fewer manual hand-offs, and consistent processing at scale.
- Measurable productivity: automation of routine query resolution reduced administrative burden.

The ceiling it hit

- Automation optimised the *process*, not the *experience*. The employee still had to initiate, wait, and follow up.
- Workflows were rigid: they executed exactly what they were built for, and no more.

Automation made processes faster and more consistent. It did not make the experience better for the person at the centre of it.

4. Phase 3. Build platforms

The paradigm. Consolidate fragmented tools into unified platforms so that services, data, and channels live in one place. A single consumer-facing identity for HR. The platform era took AI-assisted capabilities direct to employees, removing the HR-agent intermediary and scaling to multiple countries before migrating toward a governed, interoperable platform-first model.

What it unlocked

- One channel, one identity, one place to go. Fragmentation across Teams, mobile, and web was reduced.
- Reuse of shared services, including knowledge management, content, and governance, across use cases.
- Scale: from single-country deployments to global coverage across EMEA, North America, and APAC.

The ceiling it hit

- A platform still *responds*. It waits to be asked. It centralises capability but does not reason, guide, or act.
- Consolidation solved *where* the workforce goes. It did not change *what happens* when they get there.

Platforms unified the destination. The next challenge is to transform what happens when the workforce arrives.

5. Phase 4. Agentic workforce experience

The paradigm. A single front door through which every workforce persona reaches the services, information, guidance, and actions they need, powered invisibly by a network of specialised agents. This is the vision for the next generation of enterprise workforce experience: positioned not as a chatbot, a portal, or a Copilot implementation, but as an **Enterprise Workforce Experience Product**. A long-lived product with its own identity, roadmap, and governance.

What changes fundamentally

- > **One product surface**
The workforce interacts with one product. Orchestration, routing, and agent execution behind it remain invisible.
- > **Proactive, not just reactive**
The system monitors events and surfaces the right nudge, notification, or recommendation at the right moment, rather than waiting to be asked.
- > **Outcome, not just answer**
The goal of every interaction becomes the best possible outcome. The system completes the task, not just delivers the information.

The direction of travel. A workforce experience where every person has a proactive partner: all countries live at 95%+ accuracy, and the HR-partner-to-employee ratio moves well beyond 400:1.

6. What changes with agents

Agents move beyond simple chatbots. They reason, plan, and execute multi-step tasks end-to-end while keeping humans in control. Four capabilities define the shift.

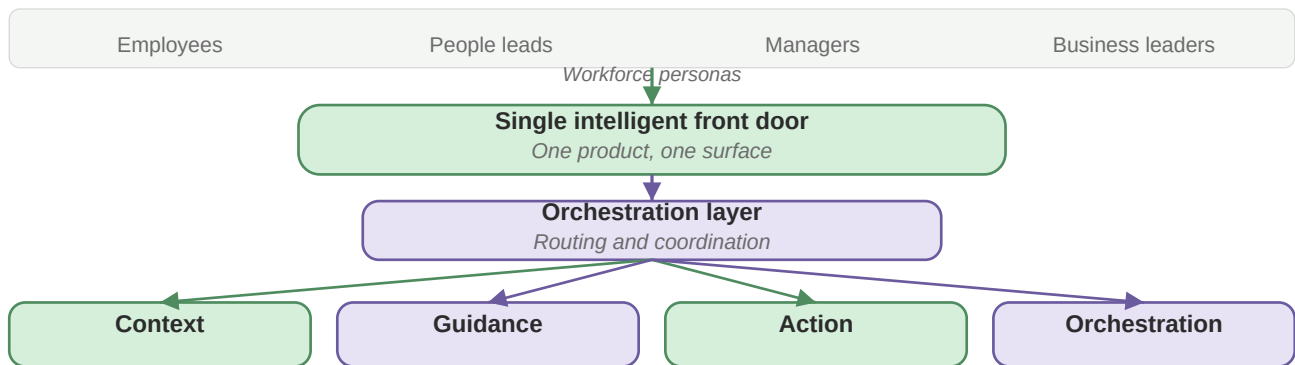


Figure 2. The four capabilities that define the agentic shift

Context

The system knows who the user is, what role they hold, what domain they operate in, and what is relevant to their current moment. Personalisation becomes the baseline, not a feature.

Guidance

Beyond returning facts, agents coach and advise. Contextual decision support, learning suggestions, and interactive multi-turn conversations at coaching-grade accuracy.

Action

The goal of every interaction becomes the best possible outcome, not merely a correct response. The system completes transactions on behalf of the employee, not just explains how to request them.

Orchestration

A network of specialised agents, skill groups, role agents, orchestrators, and utility agents, is coordinated by a layered routing model so the workforce always experiences a single, consistent surface.

7. The challenge. Trust, integration, testing and governance

Agentic systems introduce hard problems that platforms did not. Getting them right is what separates a durable enterprise product from a demo.

Trust

Agents handle sensitive workforce data, make recommendations that affect careers and assignments, and act on people's behalf. Every interaction must be explainable, every action traceable, and every data use compliant. Trust is non-negotiable.

Integration

Agents cannot live in a closed ecosystem. As enterprise platforms deploy their own agentic capabilities, enterprise agent federation, extending reach without replicating logic, becomes a core product requirement.

Testing

As the number of agents and intents grows, quality assurance must scale with it. That means regression test harnesses, evaluations, and automated quality tooling built specifically for non-deterministic agentic behaviour.

Governance

An enterprise scaling to a 3-level agent hierarchy, dozens of connected agents, and multi-team delivery needs a proven application lifecycle model: routing accuracy, observability, and human approval gates at every promotion stage.

8. The opportunity. Serving multiple workforce personas

The prize is not a smarter helpdesk. It is a single product that serves the full spectrum of the workforce, each with an experience calibrated to their role. The design principle is **build once, serve many**: orchestration, shared services, notifications, and governance are enterprise capabilities. Each corporate function that joins extends the same product rather than spawning another silo.

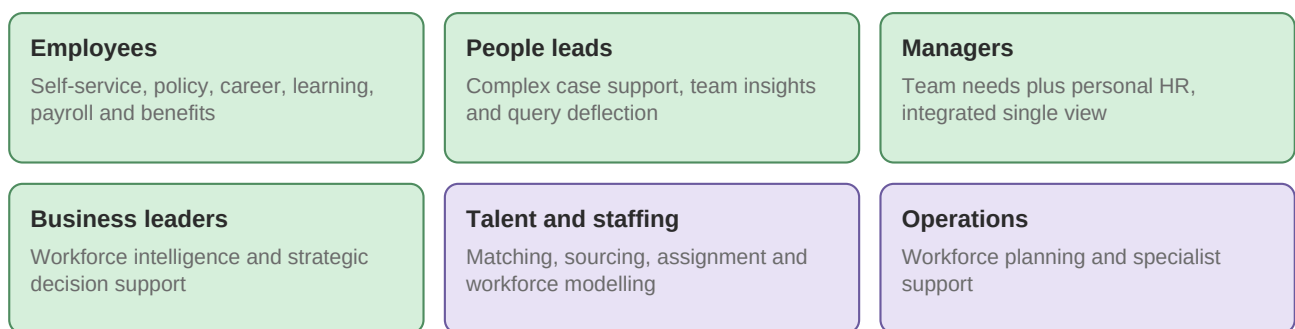
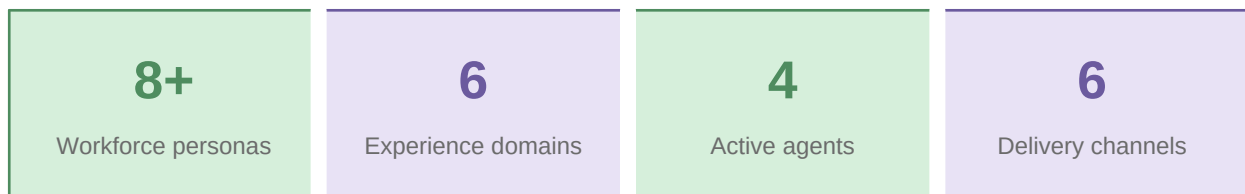


Figure 3. Workforce personas served by the agentic platform

Where the platform stands today



The roadmap points toward 8 to 10 HR skill groups and expansion across corporate functions including Finance, Legal, InfoSec, and Operations.

9. Final thought

Each phase of HR technology answered a narrower version of the same question. Digitising put information on screens. Automation made processes run. Platforms brought everything into one place. But all three ultimately *waited for the employee to act*.

The agentic era changes the verb. The system no longer just stores, routes, or responds. It understands context, offers guidance, takes action, and orchestrates outcomes. It brings the service to the employee rather than sending the employee to the service.

Phase	Paradigm	Value unit	Limitation
1	Digitise paper	Information on-demand	Employee still navigates
2	Automate workflows	Faster processing	Experience unchanged
3	Build platforms	Single destination	Still reactive
4	Agentic experience	Outcome achieved	In progress

The next HR platform will not just process work. It will help work get done.

This point of view draws on direct experience building and leading AI-driven workforce experience platforms, including regression test harnesses, evaluation platforms, and AI test generation tools. Views expressed are personal.